

4.3.1 Keys and Integrity Constraints

کینڈیڈیٹ کی وہ فیلڈ ہے جو ریکارڈ کی شناخت کر سکے۔

CS XI

Chapter 4: Data and Analysis

Lecture 04 of 15

★ Golden

4.3.1 Keys and Integrity Constraints ★ Golden

LEARN IT

A **key** is a field (or a set of fields) that uniquely identifies records and links tables. Integrity constraints are the rules that keep those keys honest.

Candidate key. Any field (or combination) that *could* uniquely identify a row. A table may have several. In an Employee table: EmpID, EmpLicense# and EmpPassport are all candidate keys.

Primary key (PK). The one candidate you actually choose. Rules: unique, never NULL, only one PK per table (it may be a **composite** of two columns). Example: EmpID.

Alternate key. The leftover candidate keys. After EmpID is chosen, EmpLicense# and EmpPassport become alternate keys — still unique, just not “the” identifier.

Foreign key (FK). A field in this table that refers to the PK of another table. It *may* contain duplicates (many employees in one department) and, in some designs, NULL.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Classroom analogy. Roll Number, B-Form number and phone number can all identify a student (candidate keys). The school picks Roll Number as the primary key. B-Form and phone become alternate keys. In a **Result** table, RollNo is a foreign key pointing back to Student.

Table	Field	Role
Student	RollNo	Primary key
Student	BFormNo	Alternate key
Result	RollNo	Foreign key → Student.RollNo
Result	ExamID + RollNo	Could be a composite primary key

EXAM TIP

Board questions: “Differentiate primary and foreign key” (table of 4 points) and “Why can a PK not be NULL?” Because a NULL would mean “this row has no identity”, so the DBMS could not tell rows apart.

COMMON MISTAKE

A phone number is a bad PK: people change numbers, two siblings may share one, and some students have none (NULL). Roll numbers are issued by the school and stay unique.

اردو میں سمجھیں

کینڈیڈیٹ کی وہ فیلڈ ہے جو ریکارڈ کی شناخت کر سکے۔ پرائمری کی منتخب شدہ شناخت ہے — منفرد اور خالی نہیں۔ جو بچ جائیں وہ الٹرنیٹ کیز ہیں۔ فارن کی دوسرے ٹیبل کی پرائمری کی طرف اشارہ کرتی ہے اور ٹیبلز کو جوڑتی ہے۔

CHECK YOURSELF

1. Can a table have two primary keys?
2. Can a foreign key have duplicate values?

Answers: 1. No — only one PK (it may be composite). 2. Yes — many child rows may point to the same parent.

Next lecture: 4.3 Relational Database Management System (RDBMS)